

**HRD Strategies that foster and enable the adaptability of managers within
rapidly changing for-profit organisations in the Netherlands**

Sandra Ahlers

Dissertation Proposal

I, Sandra Ahlers, declare that I am the sole author of this assignment and the work is a result of my own investigations, except where otherwise stated. I confirm that I have read the University regulations on plagiarism. This assignment has been proofread for matters of punctuation, grammar and spelling by an anonymous editor of Scribbr (<https://www.scribbr.com>)

All references have been duly cited.

© Sandra Ahlers 2018

This material is copyright the author. It is reproduced here by permission. Further reproduction without the explicit permission of the author is prohibited.

If you are citing this work, please refer to it as: Sandra Ahlers 2018 *HRD Strategies that foster and enable the adaptability of managers within rapidly changing for-profit organisations in the Netherlands* Dissertation Proposal submitted for the award of MA Leading Innovation and Change; York St John University

Effective word count (words used): 2.169 (excluding cover page, table of contents and references)

TABLE OF CONTENTS

1.	Introduction.....	4
2.	Methodology	6
3.	Literature Review	7
4.	Timeline.....	10
5.	Limitations.....	10
6.	References	11

1. Introduction

'It is not the strongest of the species that survives, nor the most intelligent that survives. It is the one that is the most adaptable to change - Charles Darwin' (Kemp, et al., 2001, p. 251)

The speed in which today's business landscape changes empathises the importance of adaptability (Van Dam, 2013). The concept of adaptability is not new, however, to cope with the fast-paced changes, researchers and practitioners are increasingly interested in learning how adaptability in the workplace can be developed (Pulakos, et al., 2000). Continuous improvement of adaptive behaviour, through human resource development (HRD) strategies such as training, assessment and development programs, have been proven to be essential for anticipating organisational change (Chitulescu, 2012; Yukl & Mahsud, 2010). In this context, the role of HRD becomes increasingly important in the development of adaptability.

This research will focus on HRD strategies that foster and enable adaptability in fast paced changing for profit organisations. Although the extent to which individuals are able to adapt depend on many variables that should be treated interdependent (Noel & Dennehy, 1991), the focus of this paper is narrowed to adaptive skills. Whilst adaptive skills are important for employees at all levels of the organisation, the scope of this research will be limited to the adaptability of managers.

Adaptive managers are increasingly important in a world wherein the pace of change and the effects on the organisation increase (Yukl & Mahsud, 2010). Moreover, adaptive managers are able to promote and encourage the adaptability of others by demonstrating this quality themselves. The more adapt an individual becomes, the more adaptable they will be as managers (Calarco, 2006). Therefore, the literature review in this study will comprise theories of both individual and leadership adaptability.

Having worked in the human resource industry for more than twenty years, I have experienced how the manager's approach towards change is a key factor for the success or failure of change efforts. Many organisational aspects, such as structure, culture and systems play a role before ('unfreezing') and during the change process ('refreezing') (Lewin, 1947). However, during the change processes I was involved in, paying attention to people by providing HRD opportunities promoted more belief and engagement than other forms of interventions. In this research, I would

like to gather concrete evidence to confirm my observations.

Aim

The principal aim of the research is to examine HRD strategies that contribute to successful adaptability of management to fast-paced changes.

Research question

What HRD strategies enable and foster the adaptability of managers within fast changing for-profit organisations in the Netherlands?

The proposed **research objectives** are:

1. To analyse the literature on the concept and relevancy of individual adaptability within a fast-changing organisational environment and to examine the factors that determine the extent to which a manager is able to adapt.
2. To evaluate different HRD strategies and the extent to which these strategies can be applied effectively to enable the adaptability of the manager in fast-changing for-profit organisations in the Netherlands.
3. To make recommendations on which HRD strategies can enable and foster the adaptability of managers in fast changing organisations.

2. Methodology

An **exploratory research** approach will be used to get a good understanding of the concept and meaning of individual adaptability within different organisations. A literature search will be conducted to get insights into the different views on adaptability and the related concepts needed for successful change efforts. The HRD strategies that are proven to be effective will be explored in more depth. Following this, qualitative data will be gathered by conducting semi-structured interviews.

The research method is **inductive**, meaning that new information will arise from the literature review and the interviews that will lead to general conclusions. The information and observations gathered from the interviews will be used to formulate new theories on how to develop adaptability and thus develop new HRD strategies (Saunders, 2011). The outcomes of this research could also allow further deductive research based on a hypothesis stating that when these HRD strategies are applied, the adaptability of manager will be enhanced and fostered (Hayes, et al., 2018).

The research is an **interpretivist research**. I aim to understand the link between people's ability to adapt and an organisation's conscious activities to foster and enhance this ability (Fisher, 2010). The use of an interpretivist perspective is particularly applicable, since the research aims to understand the interplay between different organisational elements, such as change, behaviour, strategies and the environment. I acknowledge that the choice of my research approach is influenced by my individual values, beliefs and feelings as well as my experience as an HRD professional. Therefore, I will constantly reflect on how I am interpreting my findings, and I will also discuss my interpretations with other professionals to get a broader perspective (Saunders, 2011).

In the qualitative component of this research, a number of organisations will be compared. Specifically, 12 HRD professionals working in different fast-changing organisations in the Netherlands will be interviewed. These interviews will explore their insights into the HRD strategies they use to develop individual adaptability as well as how effective they perceive these strategies to be in the development of their managers. From the perspective of interpretivism, interviewees are allowed to take the conversation in the direction they feel best reflects their situation (Fisher, 2010). Although qualitative research is more likely to be subjective and takes up a great deal of time, the choice of this type of research is based on the possibility that it grants to dive deeper into the ideas of the interviewee and anticipate the issues that emerge directly (Easterby-Smith, et al., 2015). The

interview data will be coded using thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2006).

3. Literature Review

Introduction

The constant changes in the today's organisational environment have increased the demand for employees that are able to continuously adapt (Van den Heuvel, et al., 2013; Van Dam, 2013). Although individual adaptability is vital at all levels of an organisation, companies should especially focus on the adaptability of their managers. If managers are not willing to change, their team members will not be encouraged to adapt either (Calarco, 2006). Thus, managers have a great influence on an employee's willingness and readiness to change, elements that are critical to the success of organisational changes (Judge, et al., 1999; Kotter, 2002). Additionally, adaptive managers are more aware of the changes in their environment and the impact these changes have on their organisation (McCarthy, et al., 2005). It seems evident that organisations need insights into how they can provide opportunities to foster and enable the adaptability of their managers and implement change successfully (Chitulescu, 2012).

Adaptability

This literature review extensively investigates the concept of the adaptability of individuals within a working environment and the factors that influence this adaptability (Pulakos, et al., 2000; Van Dam, 2013). However, Van Dam (2013) highlights that the concept of adaptability is not well understood. A clear definition of this notion is required for further theoretical research. Van Dam argues that the problem is that many definitions focus only on one aspect of adaptability. Conversely, she distinguishes three key aspects: cognitive, the alertness to notice changes and the ability to modify thoughts and ideas accordingly; affective, the ability to bounce back from emerging changes; and behavioural, the skills to adjust to changes in an environment. Many definitions of adaptability are centred on behaviour and emphasise that individual adaptability involves modifying one's behaviour to cope with changes in the environment and taking actions to respond to these changes in an effective way (Pulakos, et al., 2000). Similarly, Yukl and Mahsud (2010) state that adaptive leadership is about adjusting behaviour in a way that is suitable for a changing situation. Nansubuga and Munene (2013) only address affective adaptability, describing it as 'the readiness to scan changes in the work environment and solve difficult problem accurately'. Although the importance of adaptability is evident, research on this topic, in particular on adaptive leadership, is still limited (Yukl & Mahsud, 2010). In this paper, the definition of Van Dam (2013, p. 127) will be used since it provides a clear scope for further exploration of the different aspects of adaptability: 'Individual adaptability at work refers to employees' underlying potential as derived from cognitive, affective, and behavioral resources that can be applied to effectively adjust and/or anticipate to task-related,

environmental and vocational demands.'

Related concepts

Many researchers question how individuals survive constant changes and how they can be helped to become successful contributors (Parent, et al., 2012). A large number of concepts that are related to and intertwined with adaptability play a role in this (Löf, 2010). Van Dam's (2013) 'model for individual adaptability' reveals a variety of personal resources that influence the extent to which an individual is able to adapt. These resources are either connected to the ability to adapt or strong determinants for the extent to which someone is able to develop adaptive skills. One such resource is self-efficacy, a theory of Bandura (1988).

Self-efficacy is the cognitive ability to continue to perform properly whilst the working environment is changing (Jimmieson, et al., 2004). In the literature, self-efficacy is often wrongly equated with the concept of the 'locus of control', the perception of control over a working environment (Judge, et al., 1999). It in fact concerns the perception of available skills that an individual has and that are needed to respond to a changing situation and ensure a certain outcome. Vakola, et al. (2004) demonstrate a positive relationship between emotional intelligence and the ability to adapt to organisational changes. Their research emphasises the idea of open-minded employees able to manage themselves and use their emotions to solve problems and adapt quickly. Oreg, et al (2011) assert that adaptive behaviour is connected to willingness, openness and readiness to change. These behaviours also influence the extent to which individuals are able to cope with organisational changes. Although coping (the way individuals handle changing events) and adaptability represent different behaviours, they are fundamentally similar (Parent, et al., 2012). To understand the importance of adaptability, concepts related to it should be further explored. This could allow for a better understanding of the factors that enable adaptability.

HRD Strategies

Human resource development strategies aim to align business strategy with employees' capabilities and can be defined as 'a set of intentional activities that increase a person's skills, abilities, and/or knowledge, and direct them for a company's benefit' (Luoma, 2000, p. 771). To develop effective strategies, HRD professionals should have knowledge of the factors that foster and hinder a manager's adaptability. Too often, HRD strategies are based on pre-assumptions (Dent & Galloway Goldberg, 1999). Dent and Galloway Goldberg argue that the perception of individuals as a source of resistance is obsolete and can lead HRD efforts in the wrong direction. Therefore, traditional views such as this should be set aside to truly understand what factors boost or block adaptability (Van den

Heuvel, et al., 2013; Oreg, et al., 2011). Armenakis and Harris (2009) suggest that organisations need to know what change-recipients believe about the proposed change to understand how their readiness for change is influenced. In sum, it can be concluded that effective HRD strategies can only be developed when organisations know and understand what factors determine their ability to adapt.

Human resource development strategy should be linked to business strategy, within which the appropriate behaviours must be identified (Noel & Dennehy, 1991). Although HRD can have a significant influence on the successful execution of business strategy, a large number of organisational aspects impact the performance and change efforts. Therefore, HRD is not the answer to every organisational challenge. Without the presence of an effective system, involvement of leadership, clear structure and a supportive culture, HRD strategies do not solely suffice to improve adaptability.

It can be concluded that, Human resource development professionals must provide development opportunities to enhance and develop the adaptability of their managers, in order to fully engage people in their change efforts (Vakola, et al., 2004). It is well accepted that HRD strategies, such as training and learning experiences, can enhance and change an individual's ability to adapt (Calarco, 2006). Considering that individual resources, such as resilience, flexibility and cognitive abilities are intertwined and can limit the extent to which individuals can develop the ability to adapt, all types of adaptability can be enhanced and developed (Van Dam, 2013). This paper examines which HRD strategies are the most effective.

4. Timeline

Table 1

	2018	2019					
	December	January	February	March	April	May	June
Literature review	Submit proposal	Continue literature review	Continue literature review	Finalise draft literature review	Submit draft literature review		Submit final dissertation JUNE 9 th 2019
Research		Set up interviews	Conduct interviews	Process interviews	Write up findings	Submit draft research	
Supervision		Discuss draft interview set up with supervisor		Discuss draft literature review with supervisor		Discuss draft with supervisor	

5. Limitations

The outcome of this research will not be exhaustive - the scope and complexity of the underlying topic is far too broad for the limited scope of this study. The research is limited to the exploration of HRD strategies that provide opportunities for the development of adaptive management skills, using a literature study and interviews as research methodology. The literature review presents a selection of the HRD strategies deemed most valuable for adaptability. However, it is not the objective of this paper to provide a comprehensive review of these strategies. Further limitations and measures are listed in Table 2.

Table 2

Limitations	Measures
Bias from the interviewer and interviewee emerging from personal values, beliefs and experiences will influence reflections on organisation.	The interviewer needs to be aware of bias through constant (self) reflection. The interviewer should deepen the conversation with the interviewee to get knowledge of the values and beliefs of the interviewee and to understand how these affect the answers of the interviewee.
The effectiveness of HRD strategies can be perceived differently by the interviewee depending on the context and type of organisation. Therefore, the recommendations given cannot be applied in general but are merely suggestions that have been proven effective under certain circumstances and contexts.	The recommendations only provide a first step in developing an hrd strategy for developing adaptability. A clear description of the organisational circumstances within which the hrd strategies are effective should be given.
The size of an organisation can play a role in the outcome. Small organisations might not have the resources to develop the hrd strategies needed to enable adaptability which will influence the view of the interviewee.	- The research does not take the size of the organisation into account but will provide summary rapport of the type of organisations in which the interviewees are employed. - The influence of limited resources will be addressed during the interview.

6. References

- Armenakis, A. A. & Harris, S. G., 2009. Reflections: our Journey in Organizational Change Research and Practice. *Journal of Change Management*, 9(2), pp. 127-142.
- Bandura, A., 1988. Self-efficacy conception of anxiety. *Anxiety Research*, pp. 77-98.
- Calarco, A., 2006. In: *Adaptability: Responding Effectively to Change*. sl:Center for Creative Leadership, p. 32.
- Chitulescu, B. E., 2012. Making Change Happen: The imoact of Work Context on Adaptive and Proactive Behaviors. *The Journal of Applied Behavioral Science*, 49(2), pp. 206-245.
- Dent, E. B. & Galloway Goldberg, S., 1999. Challenging "Resistance to Change". *Journal of Applied Behavioral Science*, 35(1), pp. 35-41.
- Easterby-Smith, M., Thorpe, R. & Jackson, P., 2015. The Philosophy of Management and Business Research. *Management and business research*, Volume 5, pp. 45-65.
- Fisher, C. M., 2010. In: *Researching and writing a dissertation: an essential guide for business students*. Harlow : Financial Times Prentice Hall: sn, pp. 31-89.
- Hayes, B. K., G. Stephens, R., C. Dunn, J. & Ngo, J., 2018. The Dimensionality of Reasoning: Inductive and Deductive Inference can be Explained by a Single Process. *Journal of Experimental Psychology*, 44(9), p. 1333–1351.
- Jimmieson, N. L., Terry, D. J. & Callan, V. J., 2004. A Longitudinal Study of Employee Adaptation to Organizational Change:The Role of Change-Related Information and Change-Related Self-Efficacy. *Journal of Occupational Health Psychology* , Volume 9, pp. 11-27.
- Judge, T. A., Thoresen, C. J., Pucik, V. & Welbourne, T. M., 1999. Managerial coping with organizational change: a dispositional perspective. *Journal of Applied Psychology*, 84(1), pp. 107-122.
- Kemp, J., Moerman, P. & Prieto, J., 2001. On the Nature of Knowledge-intensive Organisations: Strategy and Organisation in the New Economy. *Journal of knowledge management*, p. 251.
- Kotter, J. P., 2002. In: *The Heart of Change, Real-Life Stories of How People Change Their Organizations*. Boston, Massachusetts: Harvard Business School Press, p. 190.
- Löf, A., 2010. Exploring adaptability through learning layers and learning loops. *Environmental Education Research*, Issue 16, pp. 5-6, 529-543 .
- Lewin, K., 1947. *Frontiers of Group Dynamic*, sl: Human Relations.
- Luoma, M., 2000. Investigating the link between strategy and HRD. *Personnel Review*, 29(6), pp. 769-790.
- McCarthy, J. F., O'Connell, D. J. & T. Hall, D., 2005. Leading beyond tragedy: the balance of personal identity and adaptability. *Leadership & Organization Development Journal*, 26(6), pp. 458-475.
- Nansubuga, F. & Munene, J. C., 2013. Adaptability to the Turbulent Work Environment Through Reflection. *The Psychologist-Manager Journal*, 16(3), pp. 160-175.
- Noel, J. L. & Dennehy, R. F., 1991. Making HRD a force in strategic organisational change. *Industrial and Commercial Training*, 23(2), pp. 17-20.
- Oreg, S., Vakola, M. & Armenakis, A., 2011. Change recipients' reactions to organizational change: A 60-year review of quantitative studies. *The Journal of Applied Behavioral Science*, Volume 47, p. 461–524.
- Parent, J. D. et al., 2012. A Model and Test of Individual and Organization Factors Influencing Individual Adaptation to Change. *Organization Management Journal*, 9(4), pp. 216-235.
- Pulakos, E. D., Arad, S., Donovan, M. A. & Plamondon, K. E., 2000. Adaptability in the workplace: development of a taxonomy of adaptive performance. *Journal of applied plycholoty*, 85(4), pp. 612-624.
- Saunders, M. N., 2011. Choosing your research design. In: *Doing research in business and management: an essential guide to planning your project*. sl:Harlow: Financial Times Prentice Hall, pp. 102-130.
- Tracy, S. J., 2012. Data analysis basics, a pragmatic iterative approach. In: *Qualitative research methods: collecting evidence, crafting analysis, communicating impact*. West-Sussex, UK: Wiley-Blackwell, pp. 231-251.
- Vakola, M., Tsausis, I. & Nikolaou, I., 2004. *Journal of Managerial Psychology*, 19(2), pp. 88-110.
- Van Dam, K., 2013. *Employee adaptability to change at work: a multidimensional, resource-based framework*. [Online] Available at: <https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9781139096690.009> [Geopend December 2018].
- Van den Heuvel, M., Demerouti, E., Bakker, A. B. & Schaufeli, W. B., 2013. Adapting to change: The value of change information and meaning-making. *Journal of Vocational Behavior*, Issue 83, pp. 11-21.
- Yukl, G. & Mahsud, R., 2010. Why Flexible and Adaptive Leadership is Essential. *Consulting Psychology Journal: Practice and Research*, 62(2), p. 81–93.